

deadlocked at 4-4, but the Italian had, tellingly, won their last three matches. From the get-go, Sinner bludgeoned the ball so hard that Djokovic gave precious ground. His average hit point during groundstroke rallies of one foot behind the baseline during his six previous matches increased to 4.5 feet. During the Serb's storied career, he'd been the great adapter and the best at turning defence into offence. But overpowered and out-steadied, Djokovic dropped the opening set 6-4.

Chants of "Nole! Nole!" revitalised the gallant but ageing Serb. And he finally broke serve for 5-5, ending Sinner's amazing 45 straight holds against the greatest serve returner in tennis history. The breathtaking shot-making that both protagonists made look routine got even better in the critical 11th game, which ended with Sinner's dynamic swinging forehand volley winner. That service break put Sinner ahead 6-5.

During the changeover, Djokovic took a three-minute medical time-out, and the physio treated his left thigh. After Sinner held serve to wrap up the second set 7-5, Patrick McEnroe said, "Now we'll see what Djokovic has left. We know he has the heart. We know he has the will. But does he have the legs?"

Djokovic had rebounded from two sets down eight times before, but in the twilight of his 21-year career, this would prove his most daunting challenge. Never the crowd favourite when he faced Roger Federer anywhere and Nadal here, Djokovic became the sentimental favourite, as ageing champions often do. With Sinner serving at 4-5, Djokovic created three set points. The crowd roared after each of them. But Sinner calmly staved them all off. When Djokovic held serve for 6-5 with a 98-mph forehand winner and an ace, the crowd did the wave as a tribute to both competitors.

In the tie-break, two backhand errors and a shanked smash into the net gave Sinner a 3-0 lead. This time, chants of "Nole! Nole!" reverberating around the stadium could not lift the tiring Djokovic. Sinner seized the

tie-break 7-3 and won the high-quality, 3-hour and 16-minute match 6-4, 7-5, 7-6 (3).

Djokovic smiled, acknowledged the prolonged applause with a tap to the heart, and thanked the crowd. The three-time French Open champion and four-time runner-up then knelt down and kissed the red clay. Was it a good-bye kiss? He said he didn't know.

Summit proportions

If there had been any lingering doubts about their total domination, the new Big Two emphatically dispelled them on June 8. This Grand Slam final would be their first against each other and the first between two men born in the 2000s. And it proved to be historic.

When Sinner saved his sixth break point in the opening set with a 105-mph forehand winner, an awed John McEnroe said, "Hitting forehands in triple digits was unheard of not long ago." Alcaraz countered with a rocket forehand winner to get another break point, which he converted. This was video game tennis on clay, as both players overpowered the sport's slowest surface and often their opponent in rapid-fire exchanges that pushed their racket skills, court speed, and athleticism to almost superhuman limits. The Spaniard lost his concentration in the 10th game, making four unforced errors, to give away the set, 6-4.

It was too soon for Alcaraz fans to panic as their hero had lost the first set in four of his last five matches, yet went on to win them all. But they had to worry when Sinner, like a speeding freight train, raced ahead 3-0 in the second set. Alcaraz — desperate for a service break and ignited by chants of "Carlos! Carlos!" — attacked furiously and forced three Sinner errors to break for 5-4 Sinner. Three more service holds made it 6-all and tiebreak time. Both had excelled in tiebreaks this season with Sinner 6-1 and Alcaraz 9-3. The Italian took this one 7-4 with a blazing cross-court forehand that overpowered Alcaraz's vaunted forehand.

Alcaraz was 0-8 after losing the first two sets at a Major. On the other



Back in business: Despite playing only his third tournament of the year due to a three-month drug suspension, Sinner had shown no signs of rust. GETTY IMAGES

hand, he was a brilliant 12-1 in five-set matches, losing only to Matteo Berrettini at the 2022 Australian Open, while Sinner was 1-5 in his previous six five-setters.

Alcaraz vented his frustration at his player box after losing his serve to start the third set. But the tide turned quickly as he broke Sinner's serve three times, the last at love. Alcaraz clinched the 6-4 set with an unreturnable forehand volley into the open court.